BENGALURU BIDS TO GET OUT OF A JAM

THE GARDEN CITY'S IMAGE OF BEING PERENNIALLY STUCK IN TRAFFIC DESPERATELY NEEDS AN OVERHAUL, BUT WHETHER THE CONGRESS REGIME'S ₹73,600 CRORE MOBILITY INFRASTRUCTURE PLAN IS THE ANSWER IS UP FOR DEBATE

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The first flyover in Bengaluru opened in 1999, marking the beginning of a pivotal period when the city's software-fuelled growth at the turn of the millennium would transform it into a global technology hub. But today, despite 42 elevated roads, the southern metropolis remains infamous for its traffic snarls. And that is because of a teeming vehicle count—there are an estimated 12 million vehicles in a city of 14 million people. All that may well change now if Karnataka deputy chief minister D.K. Shivakumar has his way and implements an ambitious new plan, which will rid the garden city of its traffic woes.

The minister in charge of Bengaluru city development, Shivakumar's to-do list is long, but topmost on it is implementing a wide-ranging mobility infrastructure plan worth Rs 73,600 crore. The biggest item on this list is 40 km of underground road corridors, touted to be the largest stretch of urban tunnels in India. These are estimated to cost Rs 42,000 crore, almost as much as the expense on the 80 km of additional metro rail lines being planned in the city under Phase 3 and 3A. In addition, there will be 110 km of elevated corridors and grade separators, estimated to cost Rs 13,200 crore, along with a Rs 9,000 crore plan for 40 km of elevated roads. These roads will be integrated with the upcoming phase of overhead metro rail stretches, creating what will be called double-decker flyovers. There is also a plan to construct 300 km of new roads running along the buffer zones of the city's stormwater drain network.

The ambitious plan for Bengaluru was the highlight of the Karnataka budget for 2025-26, presented on March 7. It has been two years in the making, primarily because the Siddaramaiah-led Congress government has been hamstrung by the huge expenditure on five big-ticket welfare schemes that were part of its pre-poll promises. It now plans to borrow more, taking advantage of the head-